



Purple patch: Shubman Gill scored a colossal 754 runs — the most by an Indian skipper in a Test series. GETTY IMAGES

Where the seam once sang, silence now reigns

An in-depth look at how England's flat-pitch strategy under Brendon McCullum turned a historic Anderson-Tendulkar Trophy into a batting feast — and why the **silence of the seam** may signal deeper risks for the future of Test cricket at home.

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The first-ever Anderson-Tendulkar Trophy witnessed a dramatic conclusion as India edged out England by six runs in the fifth Test at The Oval to level the series 2-2.

The victory at The Oval — India's narrowest win while bowling last in a Test — was a fitting finale to a

see-saw contest that stretched across all 25 allocated days of the series.

While there was no shortage of drama both on and off the field, one constant across the five matches was the relative ease of run-scoring.

On placid pitches that defied conventional expectations of swing- and seam-friendly English conditions, batters flourished while bowlers

laboured for breakthroughs.

The final aggregate run tally stood at 7,187 — the second-highest in a bilateral Test series. Only the 1993 Ashes, in which England and Australia amassed 7,221 runs across six Tests, has seen more.

England and India averaged 41.30 runs per wicket, the highest in any series of five or more Tests in over 16